

STADTTHEATER, HAMBURG

Mahler was chief conductor at the Stadttheater in Hamburg between 1891 and 1897. He conducted almost 750 performances there over these six years.

A spiritual venture

Recognized as a prodigy, Mahler was sent to the Vienna Conservatory when he was 15. During his three years there, and a further three years at Vienna University, he was inducted into the most advanced German culture of his day, absorbing the influence of Richard Wagner in music and Friedrich Nietzsche in philosophy. He learned to see music as an epic spiritual venture, a search for meaning in a world of suffering. Hugely critical of his own work, he destroyed most of his youthful compositions. A single movement of a piano quartet, written when he was 16, has survived. At the end of his student years, he wrote an ambitious cantata, *Das klagende Lied* (Song of Lamentation), but it failed to win a composition prize in 1881 and went unperformed until 1901.

Needing to earn a living, Mahler embarked on a career as a conductor. A series of appointments carried him from the smallest of provincial opera houses via Kassel, Prague, and Leipzig to prestigious appointments at the Royal Opera House in Budapest in 1888 and at Hamburg's Stadttheater, where he held the baton from 1891 to 1897. A fanatical perfectionist with poor social skills and no respect for other people's feelings, he was often loathed by the musicians he directed and in open conflict with the opera management. But the quality of the performances